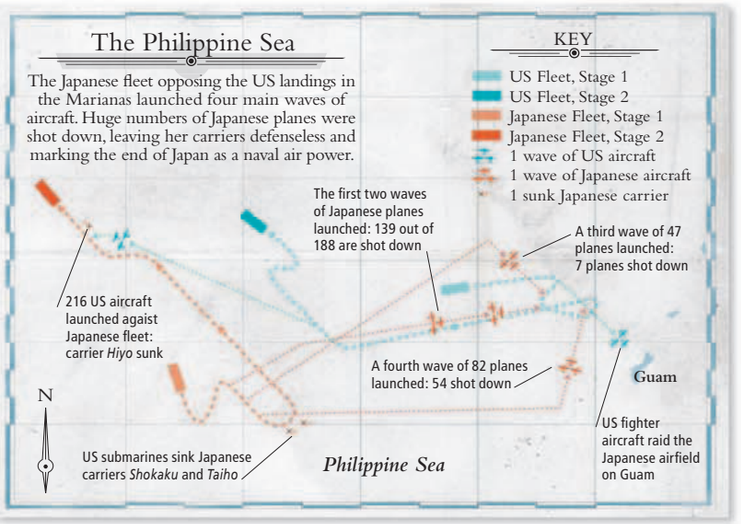
THE BATTLE OF THE PHILIPPINE SEA

By the summer of 1944 the Americans held the strategic initiative in the Pacific War. Without any source of intelligence on US planning, the Japanese were reduced to guessing where the next blow might fall. The target chosen by the Americans in June 1944 was the Mariana Islands, which would provide bases for bomber aircraft within range of Japan. Admiral Raymond Spruance sent Task Force 58 under Vice Admiral Marc Mitscher to support landings on Saipan with bombardment by carrier aircraft and naval guns. Japanese Vice Admiral Osawa Jisaburo, with a force of carriers and battleships, was 2,000 miles (3,000 km) to the south when the Japanese realized the Marianas would be the next battleground. He steamed north at speed, hoping to catch the Americans between his carriers and airbases on the islands.

The battle began on the morning of June 19. For the Japanese it was an unmitigated disaster. The waves of aircraft sent to attack the American fleet met a sophisticated defense system. Incoming aircraft were detected by radar, allowing the carrier Combat Information Centers to scramble fighters and vector them onto the intruders. The Japanese pilots were less experienced than the Americans and had no aircraft to match the Grumman Hellcats. The few who survived being pounced on by the fighters were shot down by anti-aircraft fire. In total the Japanese lost over 300 aircraft in what became known as the "Marianas Turkey Shoot." Meanwhile, American submarines preyed on the Japanese carrier force with first *Taiho* and then *Shokaku* struck by torpedoes.

The following day Mitscher sought to complete the victory with an air strike on the Japanese fleet. The Americans did not locate the enemy naval force until late in the afternoon. Mitscher decided to launch his aircraft although they would be operating at extreme range and would have to return after nightfall. The attack was largely successful, sinking the carrier *Hiyo* for the loss of a handful of aircraft, but the return journey proved to be a nightmare for the naval aircrews. Some 80 aircraft ran out of fuel before reaching the US carriers and were forced to ditch in the ocean, although the majority of the aircrews were rescued.

The battle of the Philippine Sea destroyed the Japanese carriers as a fighting force. The losses of aircraft and pilots were even more crippling than the losses of ships. Another step had been taken toward the total dominance of the US Navy in the Pacific.



WORLD WAR II



THE PHILIPPINE SEA

Date	June 19–20, 1944
Location	Philippine Sea, Western Pacific
Result	United States Victory

COMBATANTS

UNITED STATES	JAPAN

COMMANDERS

Raymond Spruance **Marc Mitscher**	**Osawa Jisaburo**

FORCES

Ships: 15 carriers, 7 battleships, 21 cruisers, 69 destroyers	**Ships:** 9 carriers, 5 battleships, 13 cruisers, 28 destroyers

LOSSES

Ships: none **Aircraft:** 123	**Ships:** 3 carriers **Aircraft:** 600



Turkey Shoot
Part of the propeller from a Japanese plane that crashed into the carrier *Essex* during the one-sided air battle American aviators and sailors nicknamed the "Marianas Turkey Shoot."

Battleship Iowa
USS *Iowa*'s huge 16-in guns were used to bombard Japanese positions on Saipan and Tinian during the Marianas campaign, and helped to protect the US carriers at the battle of the Philippine Sea.